revenue at 120 million silver coins, compared to forty-five million for the Ottoman Empire and just fifteen million for neighbouring Iran'.

This empire was created through the military genius of Akbar, and settled by his psychologically acute understanding of human nature. As he began to expand his domain, he disregarded all the old rules of warfare that had been used in the country and used speed, fury, and firepower in such a manner that it appeared as though he was able to bend the very forces of nature to his will. In battle after battle, in Malwa, Gujarat, and Rajasthan, he crossed deserts, forded rivers, and led men across the country at such speed and in such harsh conditions that these feats were deemed almost miraculous, his enemies left literally awestruck. Nor were these simply acts of physical bravado. They were carefully planned tactics, showing a fierce intelligence and a willingness to constantly evolve. Combined with this tactical skill and physical endurance, Akbar also used the relatively new gunpowder technology in innovative and previously unknown ways. Understanding the need for speed and manoeuvrability in battle, Akbar improved upon the basic musket and cannon so that artillery became portable and effective even in the harshest environments. Akbar devised ingenious rockets, and created swivel guns which could be fitted onto camels and elephants. He improved siege-craft and developed lightweight cannon that could be easily pulled into battle, as well as super-heavy cannon that could be effective against the most redoubtable fortresses. These advances and techniques, combined with the ferocity and effectiveness of Mughal mounted archers, increased accuracy and firepower to such an extent that it made the Indian battlefield the most dangerous place on earth at the time.

Once some spectacular victories had been won, Akbar was quick to use his position of strength to subdue his opponents without resorting to violence, since the cost in lives to both sides could be so high. He organized intimidating ring hunts called qumarghas, which were so effective a demonstration of his soldiers' lethal skill that opponents quickly became more circumspect. He crossed the country ceaselessly, his enormous travelling camp an eloquent testimony to the increasing wealth and power of the empire. He gave opposing generals face-saving alternatives, was willing to resort to bribery when advisable, and constantly demonstrated to the most determined enemies that it was more profitable to be part of the Mughal Empire than opposed to it.